

See also: The Representation of the People Act 188–189 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229

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Margaret Sanger

American campaigner Margaret Sanger was a champion of family planning and contraception in the early 20th century. Born in 1879, she opened the first birth control clinic in the United States in 1916. She established several birth control organizations, and she served as the first president of the International Planned Parenthood Federation, which became the world's largest nongovernmental international women's health, family planning, and birth control body. In the early 1950s, Sanger

encouraged funding for biologist Gregory Pincus to develop the birth control pill.

The success of Sanger, and also that of British campaigner Marie Stopes, in confronting almost the greatest social taboo of their age remains unmatched. Their impact on the struggle of women in the 1960s for abortion as a fundamental right cannot be underplayed. That said, Sanger essentially opposed abortion, considering birth control to be a far more effective method of preventing unwanted pregnancies. She died in 1966.

father, as often happened, women faced a lifetime of abject poverty unless they gave up the child for adoption, since they could not look after a child and work. So-called “illegitimate” children did not have the same rights of inheritance as those born “within wedlock,” and their mothers were often treated as social pariahs.

After World War I, the efforts of Margaret Sanger in the US and Marie Stopes in the UK forced some public discussion of the hitherto taboo subjects of contraception and family planning, but this had little impact for women of all classes who found themselves pregnant, since contraception and abortion were still illegal—even Sanger's advocacy of contraception resulted in her being arrested several times.

In 1920, the Soviet Union (USSR) became the first European government to legalize abortion, though its totalitarian ruler Joseph Stalin reversed the policy in 1936 to boost a population that had been decimated by purges and famine. In most countries, abortion was

viewed as a desperate last remedy, a source of shame and horror. Those women who nonetheless chose abortion not only faced the emotional trauma of being stigmatized by those around them, but also risked endangering their own lives through botched procedures performed by unqualified practitioners—so-called “back-street abortions.”

By the time of the liberalizing 1960s, a groundswell of opinion in much of the world held that anti-

abortion laws were antiquated and should be swept away. When the contraceptive pill was legalized (in the UK in 1961 and across the whole of North America by 1972), denying women the right to abortion seemed illogical and discriminatory. In the US, that right finally gained legal force in 1973, with *Roe v. Wade*.

A groundbreaking case

In 1969, 21-year-old Texan Norma McCorvey found herself pregnant with her third child and wanted an abortion, but this was illegal in Texas. McCorvey's cause was taken up by two feminist lawyers, Sarah Weddington and Linda Coffee, who recognized her case had the capacity to prove groundbreaking. They filed a lawsuit for McCorvey—who for the purposes of the legal hearing adopted the name Jane Roe to protect her identity—alleging that the Texan abortion laws were unconstitutional. The defendant in the case was Dallas County district attorney Henry Wade, who represented the State of Texas. »

“Enforced motherhood is the most complete denial of a woman's right to life and liberty.

Margaret Sanger
“*Suppression*,” published in
The Woman Rebel, 1914